



paved pathways of a broadband connection, it blurs and distorts everything it passes; trampling both definitions (what is real, Morpheus wondered) and ethics, gleefully throwing paradoxes. Take visual information, for example—computers are fast reaching the point where what you see within a game will be indistinguishable from what lies outside your window. Mommy will be one taunt short: yes mom, there are birds and trees and seas and butterflies and people inside this game. Real people, most of my friends, are in here. Look! Uncle Vijay says hi!

Dragon Empires, an MMORPG in the making, promises to offer the most realistic world that does not exist. "One of the really cool features of the game is that the landscape and sky naturally light the faces and bodies of characters. We don't need to add shadow textures or shading on textures to highlight face features, for example, because when light falls on the face and body, it gets lit naturally. No shadow texture under the nose or chin is required; the game will do this for you. The effect is quite exciting as you can see the sun form a halo behind someone's head and their face will be in shadow; when lit from below, characters look quite scary and the differences in head shapes and looks are really accentuated by natural shadows, all of which help to make characters look real," beams an artist working on *Dragon Empires*.

It's not a crime if you are making it

Even economy is not spared the simulation it never asked for. *Dragon Empires* takes a somewhat simplified approach: you can establish trade routes between cities and the outback, the cost of goods traded being inversely proportional to the ease with which they are procured. If travelling does not suit your complexion, then

The sad truth is that in many ways *EverQuest* is better than real life. It gives me an opportunity to feel free

AN EVERQUEST FAN

you can settle down and set up a factory that manufactures weapons or pottery (raw materials come from the traders). You could even set up a trade union with fellow players, one that manipulates prices, monopolises and guards its business—as seen on TV! A central market is the hub of activity, items are exchanged for money, a track of goods is kept and the equation of

demand and supply imparts a dynamic flux to the rise and fall of commodities. The rare today, becomes common place tomorrow.

Star Wars Galaxies offers a mind-numbing 50 professions that you, as a player, can immerse in. Everything from tailoring, to becoming a Jedi is covered. And what does Jack do with the money he makes selling pastries? Why, he builds himself a house! Or buys one already furnished. The money keeps flowing; both within the game and outside—from the very real pockets of Jack into the coffers of some very happy people at Sony and LucasArts.

Even here, the faculty of the human brain to take the seemingly simple and colour it with layers of intrigue and complexity does not fail. Feel the undercurrent of the designed economies of these online worlds and very real, unintended and surprisingly profitable ventures ebb and flow with delight. If you don't have something it becomes gravely important to own, money is just a hurdle. This fact often raises the status of rare weapons, armour and spells to godly heights. Even the mundane and the gross such as horse manure and bits of grass are fervently worshipped, uncommon as they are. The entrepreneurs come out of the woodwork. Rare commodities are bought and sold for real money. Auctions are held, credit card numbers are flashed and a gamer logs-off with less cash and a digital addition that he was never meant to possess within a digital realm he calls home. Players have been known to pay as much as \$1,500 for a weapon and \$350 for a pair of boots. This real-unreal nexus is a lucrative \$1 million business for some.

So why should the game developers and publishers be left out? Trying and failing to stop these underground activities, companies are shrugging and joining in the merriment. Sweden-based MindArk for one, plans to tie real commerce with its upcoming game, *Project Entropia*. Real money is used to transact within the game and game money earned and saved can be converted into real green. If you really wish to be a millionaire, perhaps you are in the wrong business. Here lies the Internet economy that was expected but never arrived. It was just playing games with us and having a good time. ■

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SOME EXCERPTS FROM: *ARIADNE—UNDERSTANDING MMORPG ADDICTION* BY NICHOLAS YEE, OCTOBER 2002. [HTTP://WWW.NICKYEE.COM/HUB/ADDICTION/HOME.HTML](http://www.nickyee.com/hub/addiction/home.html)